however, not one of these brave banners was to be seen, ‘for the great nobles had hidden them in their apprehension’.

Defeated before the fighting began, the reluctant commanders packed off their untrained servants, *ghulam*s, to the front. No sooner did these men see Sher Shah advance than they were possessed of an urge to get out of his way. The resulting chaos destroyed any semblance of discipline in the Mughal army – ‘the whole array was broken’, writes Haider – and before a gun could be fired or a commander wounded, it was each man for himself, commander and ghulam racing each other to the river in desperate flight.

Humayun’s own fate was humiliating. His water carrier and future biographer, Jouher, recalls how ‘an Afghan clothed in black’ struck Humayun’s horse with a spear.[9] Even with his horse injured and his army in a shambles – Afghan soldiers were looting Humayun’s artillery in front of his eyes – the emperor remained eager to fight, until a more sensible and anonymous hand grabbed the reins of his mount and led him to the river. Here, Humayun recognized an old elephant that had once belonged to his father, and climbed upon its back, only to realize that its driver was marching him towards the enemy. A eunuch he found hiding in the howdah whispered to Humayun to ‘take off the fellow’s head’.[10] Sensible advice, but Humayun knew nothing of driving an elephant; he would be stranded without a mahout. The eunuch assured the emperor that he knew a little about riding elephants and would take them to safety. Hacking at the treacherous driver with his sword, Humayun managed to push him to the ground, then, somehow, to cross the river – only to find the riverbank so steep he couldn’t climb up it. Eventually, two camp men saw him and tied their turbans into a rope, by which the hapless emperor, soaked and dishevelled, clambered ashore.

Abul Fazl, Akbar’s historian and greatest admirer, wrote the official and approved account of this debacle in his *Akbarnama*, ridding the story of its more farcical bits. In his telling, the emperor, ‘mounted with firm foot on an elephant’ – there is no mention of the eunuch who helped him ride it – made his way across the Ganga’s swollen waters, and climbed ashore with manly dignity, aided by one Shamsuddin Muhammad of Ghazni, a soldier whose helping hand would gain him the highest rank in the years to come.

For the moment, however, neither emperor nor soldier could hope for